

Only **51%** urban women have regular and healthy meals, while 62% mention fast, convenient food as 'ideal snacks'

sleep, exercise and nutrition. Most women who look after their families forget to look after themselves." Caught between home and work, traditional expectations and modern aspirations, there's unbelievable stress on women today.

Stress ups obesity. *Nature* magazine reported last year how the body releases a molecule, NPY (neuropeptide Y) when stressed. It unlocks the body's fat cells and makes them grow in both size and number. Cortisol, a hormone, released during the stress response, has also been implicated in developing belly fat. Also, bodies that aren't rested produce increased amounts of ghrelin, a hormone that triggers sensations of hunger, and reduces production of leptin—a hormone that regulates appetite. Is that what happened to 45-year-old Arti Banka of Mumbai? The owner of Ankur door-to-door laundry service begins her day at 5 a.m. and finishes at 11 p.m. Life wasn't always that tough for the slim and carefree daughter of a wealthy Marwari family. But as family commitments post-marriage turned her into the breadwinner—with an abusive, alcoholic husband and a depressive son—her body bore the brunt. She bloated up to 110 kg.

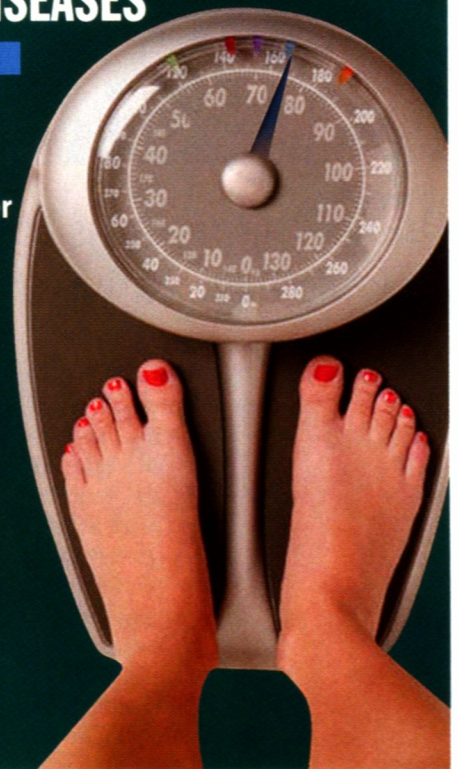
There's a biological link between stress and the drive to eat. Relief often takes the form of "comfort eating". No wonder, mindless eating is on the rise. According to a 2007 AC Nielsen survey among urban women in the five metros, only 51 per cent have regular meal times and a whopping 62 per cent mention fast, convenient food as 'ideal snacks'. Ask Deepika Sahay (name changed). "I was always slim and sporty," she says. But weight became an issue after she got married and quit her job. "As I became a homemaker from an active career-maker, I started losing interest in myself," she rues. And a vicious cycle of eating mindlessly and gaining weight took off. "Food made me happy and I started scarfing it down." But the more calorie-rich food she consumed, the more guilty she felt, and to perk-up she ate more. "Losing interest" is a re-

frain that revolves around the husband in many a 35-plus woman's life. The AIIMS cardiology unit along with the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) verified that in an obesity survey in 2004. A large number of respondents blamed the lack of sexual drive in career-obsessed husbands as the prime cause behind their apathy toward their own self.

Lisa Sarah John, who fought and won the battle of the bulge, knows how women turn food into consolation. "I was born underweight and grew up hearing 'eat, eat, eat'," says the nutrition

WEIGHTY WOMEN GET 6 TIMES MORE DISEASES

- ✓ Chronic diseases
- ✓ 10 types of cancer
- ✓ Polycystic ovary syndrome
- ✓ Miscarriage & infertility
- ✓ Dementia & Alzheimer's
- ✓ Asthma
- ✓ Psoriasis



◀ DR FIRUZA PARIKH, INFERTILITY SPECIALIST

Most women forget to look after themselves, don't get their quota of sleep, exercise and nutrition. All that adds to weight, she believes.

"I'm yet to see a lazy working woman. They forget to take care of themselves."



◀ LISA SARAH JOHN, NUTRITIONIST

She fought and won the battle of the bulge. Unlike men, she holds, women internalise stress and turn food into consolation.

"There is unbelievable stress on women these days."

